

Early tools

Our earliest human ancestors appeared in Africa more than two million years ago. Scientists gave them the Latin name *Homo habilis*, which means “handy man,” because they are believed to have made and used stone tools—the very first invention. As humans evolved, they developed increasingly complex tools for a variety of tasks.

STONE TOOLS

Early people made tools by striking round pieces of stone, such as flint or quartz, with another hard stone. This shaped the stones into handheld tools that had a wide range of uses, including chopping, scraping, and engraving. The best-known early tool was the hand ax, which could be used to dig, kill prey, carve meat, and chop wood.



Ax was shaped by chipping flakes off a stone

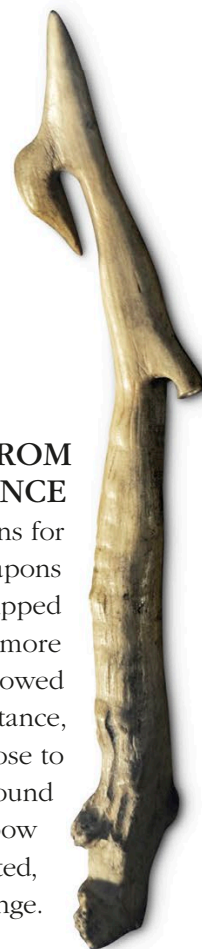
Hand ax from around 1.5 million years ago

Flint arrowhead, c. 4000 BCE



HUNTING FROM A DISTANCE

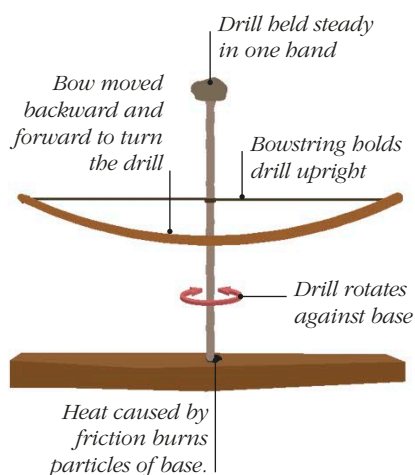
Humans needed weapons for hunting. Among the first weapons invented were wooden spears tipped with sharp stones, developed more than 400,000 years ago. These allowed hunters to attack prey from a distance, which was safer than getting up close to large and dangerous animals. Around 60,000–70,000 years ago, the first bow and arrow weapons were invented, which had an even longer range.



Harpoon made of deer antler, c. 6500–4000 BCE

MAKING FIRE

Fire was vital for cooking food as well as providing warmth and light. More than 6,000 years ago, probably in Egypt, prehistoric people invented the bow drill for lighting fires. The device was rotated to cause friction, which produced enough heat to burn small particles.



Egyptian copper workers

